

SUMMARY OF SELF-ASSESSMENT

I. TEACHING

There is a Latin proverb that translates to “By learning you will teach; by teaching you will learn.” Therefore, my most important goal is to create a learning environment that is conducive of active and evidence-based for everyone. This is true whether teaching formally or informally, and whether my audience consists of undergraduate students, graduate clinicians or even patients.

Another Native American saying that I learned during my teaching and clinical journey is “Tell me and I’ll forget. Show me, and I may not remember. Involve me, and I’ll understand.” Thus, my style of teaching evolved over the years to be more practical, experiential and occasionally humorous, which I believe leads to a collaborative learning process that benefits everyone involved.

Three very important elements in my educational philosophy; respect for the learner, appreciating different learning styles and continuous refinement of the teaching process. These elements are linked and how I use them to define my educational approach is outlined below.

Respect for the learner

In the teacher-learner dyad, each element influences the success of the educational encounter. Engaging the learner is critical. One must start by gauging the needs of the learner, tailoring the approach to the learner, and insuring a safe learning environment. A central goal is to encourage experimentation and taking chances. Consistent with this attitude of respect is my willingness to accept error and correct it quickly when it occurs. Honesty about expectations, successes and mistakes is the foundation for the respect that will insure optimal learning.

Appreciating different learning styles

As a teacher of undergraduate and graduate students, it is important to recognize and accept the diversity that is in our classrooms today. Although, there are obvious forms of diversity in classrooms like language and ethnic background differences, my focus is not on overcoming ethnic discrimination or working towards inclusion and understanding. On the contrary, I focus towards recognizing and appreciating the diversity of students as individual learners. By providing different learning opportunities for different learning styles, I can maximize learning potentials for my students as well as help my students to choose the learning techniques that work best for them.

Continuous refinement of the teaching process

I truly, believe that each teaching session is an experiment in blending unique learning needs and teaching methods. Further, assessment and evaluation are integral parts of the learning process that ensure quality and help prevent the same errors from occurring over time. Further, I believe that accepting feedback and respecting that people learn differently helps me in my continuous refinement of courses. In fact, without looking back at what I have done, I would not be informed about what I might do.

These three basic approaches to teaching are embodied in the active and reflective style of teaching I feel most comfortable with. I engage my students early on in the course syllabus planning; probe what they know, what they think and what is the best course of action. I continue to build on what they know and help them discover their own ability to become good clinicians. This approach empowers students to take responsibility in the learning process, regardless of their level of training.

II. SCHOLARSHIP AND RESEARCH

Since Joining UAEU in 2018 and despite the heavy teaching load that I carried (19 different classes), I was research active. In fact, I enjoy research and research related activities. That resulted in 11 research publications in indexed international journals in addition to several conference presentations. Further, I have 8 manuscripts that are under review in Q1 and Q2 Scopus journals. Since joining UAEU, I collaborated with, and provided training to several PhD, MA, and BA students. Additionally, I collaborated with well-known international research institutes that resulted in a contribution to the field of neuroscience and rehabilitation.

Research Philosophy and Contribution.

I believe that the future of rehabilitation fields lies at the intersection of evidence-based practice, evaluating current clinical practices, and generating new effective treatment approaches. It is relatively easy to form clinical hypotheses, but gathering data to evaluate these hypotheses, rather, difficult, and rare. Effectively gathering evidence based clinical data requires the development of new perspectives and the utilization of new available technology, and their integration with current research programs.

My research activities focused on utilizing new available technology to gather clinical data in swallowing and motor speech abilities. In particular, I utilized two relatively new technologies that are available to researchers in communication sciences and disorders. The first is neuromuscular electrical stimulation (NMES). The second is functional Near-Infrared Spectroscopy (fNIRS).

Established Neuroscience of Education Lab. Since securing a start-up funds from UAEU, I established a neuroscience of education lab. Functional Near-Infrared Spectroscopy (fNIRS) brain-imaging is a novel technology measures changes in the brain's blood oxygen level density (BOLD) while a person is performing specific motor or cognitive tasks. fNIRS scanners are very small (the size of a desktop computer), portable, and particularly child friendly (children and adults sit normally in a comfortable chair, and babies can be studied while seated on mom's lap). Establishing a neuroscience lab not only generated cutting edge and evidence-based research but also stimulated and recruited millennial student researchers to the field of education and speech language pathology.

Neuromuscular electrical stimulation research. My research work focused on exploring the use of NMES on orofacial muscles in healthy volunteers and in individuals with orofacial weakness (Safi, et. al., 2014, 2017, 2018, 2020, 2021). My experimental/empirical research demonstrated that not only it's safe to utilize NMES in the orofacial region but also its potentially an effective

treatment modality with individuals who have labial weakness, Another outcome from my research was that submental electrical stimulation did not generate any effect on lingual muscles (Safi, et. al., 2017). This research explored new frontiers in neuroscience I took steps in providing evidence based clinical research. Another area that I focused on was evaluating tolerance and comfort levels of facial NMES in healthy volunteers. I have adopted a scale to measure NMES comfort level from the researched tools that are used with patients to measure their perception of pain levels accurately. The main purpose of this research was to establish whether facial NMES is tolerable or not (Safi, 2020). Indeed, one of my other major achievements and contribution in the lab was to collaborate with senior researchers at the NIH, USA and James Madison University on a neuroscience related research that resulted in a publication in the Neuromodulation journal (Scopus Q1 Neuroscience journal).

Further, since joining the Special Education Department at CEDU-UAEU, I made slight modification to my research agenda and interest to contribute to the development and research training of students in the department by focusing as well on communication disorders and language intervention in individuals with ASD. That led to 2 co-publications with my 2 of graduate students in addition to 4 more with 2 more students that were submitted and currently under review.

III. UNIVERSITY AND COMMUNITY SERVICE

I have been a clinical Speech Language Pathologist since 2002 with a specialization in neurogenic communication disorders and dysphagia. Currently, working as an Asst. Professor in the department of Speech Language Pathology at the College of Medicine and Health Sciences as well as the department of Special Education at the College of Education – UAEU where I was serving on various committees for the past 3 years prior to the establishment of the new Speech Language Pathology Department at the College of Medicine and Health Sciences.

I have been actively serving the department, the college, the university as well as the community in providing extra training and supervision to our students as well as policy and public education services related to language and communication disorders. Furthermore, I campaigned and provided awareness regarding the field of Speech Language Pathology and Audiology to colleagues in the college of education and senior administrators at UAEU in addition to being involved in discussions and education meetings about the importance of the field and how to establish a good program on a pro bono basis with the Emirati Society for Speech Language Pathology.